VSO

TELUS
PREMIER EDUCATION PARTNER

The Spirit Horse Returns

K- Gr. 7 Study Guide

October 29 & 30, 2024

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Thank you!

Vancouver Symphony Orchestra

Otto Tausk

Conductor & Music Director

Dutch conductor Otto Tausk is the Music Director of the Vancouver Symphony Orchestra and Artistic Advisor of the VSO School of Music, now in his sixth season. He is also Chief Conductor of Phion Orkest van Gelderland & Overijssel, and until spring 2018, was Music Director of the Opera Theatre and Tonhalle Sinfonieorchester St. Gallen. He is a widely respected musical personality in his native Holland, working with all its major orchestras and composers.

Born in Utrecht, Otto Tausk initially studied violin and then conducting with Jonas Aleksa. Between 2004 and 2006, Tausk was assistant conductor to Valery Gergiev with the Rotterdam Philharmonic Orchestra, a period of study that had a profound impact on him. He received the prestigious 'De Olifant' award for his contribution to the Arts in the Netherlands, in particular his extensive work with Holland Symfonia, serving as Music Director from 2007 to 2012.

Vancouver Symphony Orchestra

Founded in 1919, the Grammy and Juno award winning Vancouver Symphony Orchestra is the third largest orchestra in Canada, the largest arts organization in Western Canada, and one of the few orchestras in the world to have its own music school.

Led by Music Director Otto Tausk since 2018, the VSO performs more than 150 concerts throughout Vancouver and the province of British Columbia each year, reaching over 270,000 people. The VSO has toured the United States, China, Korea, and across Canada. The orchestra presents passionate, high-quality performances of classical, popular and culturally diverse music, creating meaningful engagement with audiences of all ages and backgrounds.

Members of the Orchestra

Otto Tausk, Conductor & Music Director
ALAN AND GWENDOLINE PYATT PODIUM

David Bui , RBC Assistant Conductor
MARSHA AND GEORGE TAYLOR CHAIR

First Violin
Nicholas Wright, Concertmaster
RON AND ARDELLE CLIFF CHAIR
Timothy Steeves, Associate Concertmaster
WILLIAM AND IRENE McEWEN CHAIR
David Lakirovich, Assistant Concertmaster
ROBERT G. AND SUZANNE BRODIE CHAIR
Jennie Press, Second Assistant Concertmaster
Cassandra Bequary
Jae-Won Bang
Sunny She
Xue Feng Wei
Rebecca Whitling
MRS. CHENG KOON LEE CHAIR
Yi Zhou

Second Violin
Karen Gerbrecht, Associate Principal
JIM AND EDITH LE NOBEL CHAIR
Jeanette Bernal-Singh, Assistant Principal
Blythe Allers
Manuel Lok
Daniel Norton
Ann Okagaito
Ashley Plaut, Acting Assistant Principal
Carina Vincenti

Viola
Hung-Wei Huang, Principal
Andrew Brown, Associate Principal
Emilie Grimes, Assistant Principal
Katrina Chitty
Matthew Davies
ESTELLE AND MICHAEL JACOBSON CHAIR
Angela Schneider
PROFESSORS MR. AND MRS. NGOU KANG CHAIR
Jacob van der Sloot
Peter Ing
Isabelle Roland

Cello
Henry Shapard, Principal
NEZHAT KHOSROWSHAHI, OBC AND HASSAN KHOSROWSHAHI, CM, OBC, CHAIR
Janet Steinberg, Associate Principal
Zoltan Rozsnyai, Assistant Principal
Natasha Boyko
MARY AND GORDON CHRISTOPHER CHAIR
Luke Kim
DR. MALCOLM HAYES AND LESTER SOO CHAIR
Charles Inkman
Cristian Márkos
TIM WYMAN AND SUSAN GABE CHAIR
Jonathan Lo
GERHARD AND ARIANE BRUENDL CHAIR
Albert Seo

Bass
Dylan Palmer, Principal
Evan Hulbert, Associate Principal
Noah Reitman, Assistant Principal
David Brown
Malcolm Armstrong
J. Warren Long

Members of the Orchestra

Flute
Christie Reside, Principal
RON AND ARDELLE CLIFF CHAIR
Rosanne Wieringa
Dakota Martin, Assistant Principle

Piccolo
Dakota Martin
HERMAN AND ERIKA STÖLTING CHAIR

Oboe
Joo Bin Yi, Principal
WAYNE AND LESLIE ANN INGRAM CHAIR
Karin Walsh
PAUL MORITZ CHAIR
Christine Kim, Assistant Principal

English Horn
Karin Walsh
CHAIR IN MEMORY OF JOHN S. HODGE

Clarinet
Jeanette Jonquil, Principal
ROBERT G. AND SUZANNE BRODIE CHAIR
Michelle Goddard, Acting Assistant
TARYN BRODIE CHAIR
Aidan Wong

E-flat Clarinet
Michelle Goddard

Bass Clarinet
Aidan Wong

Bassoon
Julia Lockhart, Principal
Thalia Navas
Sophie Dansereau, Assistant Principal

Contrabassoon
Sophie Dansereau

French Horn
Alexander Wide, Principle
WERNER AND HELGA HÖING CHAIR
Oliver de Clercq, Associate Principal
Holly Bryan
William Loveless, Assistant Principal
WINSLOW AND BETSY BENNETT CHAIR
Andrew Mee

Trumpet
Larry Knopp, Principal
Vincent Vohradsky
Marcus Goddard, Associate Principal

Trombone
Andrew Poirier, Acting Principal
Ethan Shrier

Bass Trombone
Ilan Morgenstern
ARTHUR H. WILLMS FAMILY CHAIR

Tuba
Peder MacLellan, Principal

Timpani
Aaron McDonald, Principal
Zach Masri, Assistant Principal

Percussion
Vern Griffiths, Principal
MARTHA LOU HENLEY CHAIR

Harp
Alyssa Katahara, Principal

Piano
Bogdan Dulu
JEMINI FOUNDATION CHAIR
Grace Huang
JEMINI FOUNDATION CHAIR

Curriculum Connections

Kindergarten - Grade 7

Explore and Create

- Explore elements, processes, materials, movements, technologies, tools, and techniques of the arts
- Create artistic works collaboratively and as an individual, using ideas inspired by imagination, inquiry, experimentation, and purposeful play
- Demonstrate an understanding and appreciation for personal, social, cultural, historical, and environmental contexts in relation to the arts

Reason and Reflect

- Research, describe, interpret, and evaluate how artists (dancers, actors, musicians, and visual artists) use processes, materials, movements, technologies, tools, and techniques in the arts.
- Develop processes and technical skills in a variety of art forms to nurture motivation, development, and imagination.

Communicate and Document

- Express feelings, ideas, stories, observations, and experiences through the arts
- Describe and respond to works of art
- Experience, document, and share creative works in a variety of ways

First Peoples Principles of Learning

- Learning is holistic, reflexive, reflective, experiential and relational (focused on connectedness, on reciprocal relationships, and a sense of place.)
- Learning is embedded in memory, history, and story.
- Learning involves recognizing the consequences of one's actions
- Learning recognizes the role of Indigenous knowledge

About the Concert

The Spirit Horse Returns tells the story of the Ojibwe Horses, a breed from the Prairies that served as helpers and spirit guides to Indigenous people. With the help of Indigenous knowledge keeper Jodi Contin and settler storyteller and musician Ken MacDonald, come on a journey where we explore Indigenous ways of life from many years ago. Using the power of storytelling, visual art, and orchestral music, we can learn about reconciliation and unity through the care of this beloved horse breed and the land that we live on.

Featured Works Include:

- Across Turtle Island
- Song for Asemaa'kwe
- Song for Ajijaak
- Horses of the People
- The Métis Cart
- The Pony Express
- Fences, Borders, Reserves
- The Useless Ponies
- The Winter Rescue
- Song for the Caretakers
- Seasons Change
- Song for Geegwanens
- The Seventh Fire

Please refer to the original NACO Study Guide for more information:
English
En Francais

Meet the Creative Team!

Please refer to the NACO Study Guide for a full list of team members

A Note from the Creators:

"The Spirit Horse Returns" is the work of many co-creators from different backgrounds. Some of us are Indigenous, some have settler roots that go back many generations. We were all inspired by stories of the Ojibwe Horses and how Indigenous and non-Indigenous people have worked together to preserve and protect the breed."

Ken MacDonald - Co-creator

Acclaimed as a "French horn master" by the Toronto Star, Ken MacDonald has performed in every province with a variety of Canada's top ensembles. He is currently Associate Principal horn with the Winnipeg Symphony Orchestra, having played principal horn with the Hamilton Philharmonic Orchestra, Symphony Nova Scotia, and the Vancouver Opera Orchestra. He has also performed as a guest artist with the Vancouver Symphony, the Canadian Opera Company, the Kitchener-Waterloo Symphony, Orchestra London, the Victoria Symphony, and the Regina Symphony.

Jodi Contin - Co-creator

Jodi Contin is a highly energetic Anishinaabe Kwe who hails from Wasauksing First Nation. Empowering and lifting up others is one of the ways she holds space to encourage people to find their path to healing. Caregiving comes naturally to Jodi; she has worked in a variety of capacities in the social services industry from being employed as a Child Protection Worker and Family Support Worker and Prevention Services Supervisor. Currently Jodi is a Band Representative for Henvey Inlet First Nation. She was recently elected to the Board of Directors for the Festival of The Sound and is in the productions "Sounding Thunder" and the "The Spirit Horse Returns."

The Spirit Horse Returns

“The Spirit Pony” (2021) by Rhonda Snow

The Spirit Horse Returns intertwines perspectives of an Indigenous knowledge keeper and a settler, highlighting the history and significance of Ojibwe Horses.

Originally used by First Nations and Métis for tasks like logging and transport, these small yet powerful horses roamed free pre-colonization. Legends from Manitou Lake, and Ojibwe and Métis traditions enrich the concert with a focus on Indigenous traditions and storytelling.

As colonization altered the landscape and displaced Indigenous people, the plight of the Ojibwe horses mirrored their struggle. However, pieces like "The Winter Rescue", about a young girl rescued in a snowstorm by her pony, and “Song for Geegwanens” about the first Ojibwe horse born in living memory, provide hope for the future.

The tale culminates with Indigenous and non-Indigenous people uniting to rescue the last of the Ojibwe horses. Through reconciliation, The Spirit Horse Returns aims to teach children that when we come together to care for the land and each other, we can create a better world.

Lesson 1: Indigenous Teachings

Host Nations:

There are many different First Nations in the Salish Sea, and across Turtle Island, all with their own distinct cultures. The Vancouver Symphony works, lives and makes music on the unceded territories of the xʷməθkʷəy̓əm (Musqueam), Sḵwx̱wú7mesh (Squamish), and Sel̓íl̓ witulh (Tsleil-Waututh) Nations.

VSO Indigenous Council:

We would like to acknowledge the Indigenous Council for their contributions and allowance to share their folk tales, music, and history with Vancouver audiences on this guide. The partnership between the VSO and the Indigenous Council is one of value and respect, with a collective goal of passing on Indigenous teachings through music to the next generations

Council Members: Dennis Thomas (Whonoak), Orene Askew (Tumáliya), Charleen Grant, Rosie Johnnie-Mills, Suzanne Anton, Cristian Markos, and Angela Elster.

What Does it Mean to be Indigenous?

Imagine that you had a time machine and could travel back a thousand years, long before settlers came to North America.

There would be no cities, sidewalks, or cars, only greenery, lakes, mountains, and the homes of the Indigenous people. The word “indigenous” means “the earliest known inhabitants of a place.” This means that they have always lived on this land.

Indigenous people have cared for the land by being resourceful. Can you imagine what our world could look like if everyone was resourceful and appreciated the land?

We can learn a lot from Indigenous people about healing the planet from climate change, saving animals and plants from extinction, and connecting with and respecting the land on which we live.

What is Truth and Reconciliation All About?

At the beginning of school assemblies or events, you may have heard someone talk about a “Land Acknowledgement.”

To acknowledge something means to accept that it is true, so acknowledging the land means to accept that Indigenous people have always been here.

As our awareness of Indigenous culture grows, we are learning to reconcile, which means to recognize the wrongs of the past to try to resolve them the best we can.

Reconciliation can be accomplished in many different ways, but one way to start is by listening and learning from Indigenous people about the way that they used to live before settlers arrived.

Through listening to the music and stories of Indigenous people, we hope to offer opportunities for listening, acknowledgment, and reconciliation.

Learn more:
www.cbc.ca/kids/articles/what-is-a-land-acknowledgment

Lesson 2:

An orchestra is made up of a large group of musicians playing instruments from four main families: Strings, Woodwinds, Brass and Percussion.

Camille Saint-Saëns composed his famous Carnival of the Animals while on holiday in Austria, creating a playful "grand zoological fantasy." This piece uses orchestral instruments to bring different animals to life through music. Ready to explore the animal kingdom through music?

STRINGS

Violin, Viola, Cello and Double Bass are instruments in the Strings Family! These instruments have strings and you puck, bow or strum them to make sounds.

Listen to how the Double Basses bring “The Elephant” to life.

Can you feel the weight of each stomp of the elephants?

The Strings section is usually the largest in the orchestra. Notice how all the string players move and play together.

WOODWINDS

To produce sound on a woodwind instrument, you need both air and keys or holes to change the notes.

Here is the woodwind section:
Flute, Oboe, Clarinet, and Bassoon.

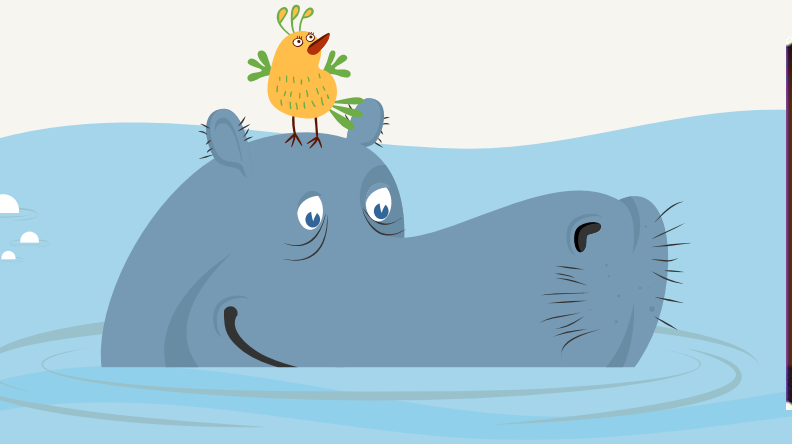
Now listen to the flute in "Aviary," showing how birds fly and flit through the air.

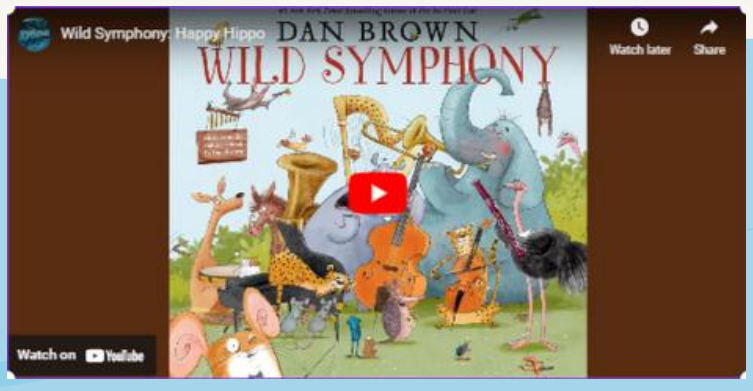
BRASS

Brass instruments, like Trumpet and Trombone, French Horn and Tuba, are shiny and make sound by buzzing your lips. Their bright, brassy tones are great for marches and fanfares!

Here is a movement from Dan Brown's Wild Symphony and features the WHOLE Brass section

What are some words that you think of when you hear the Brass instruments?



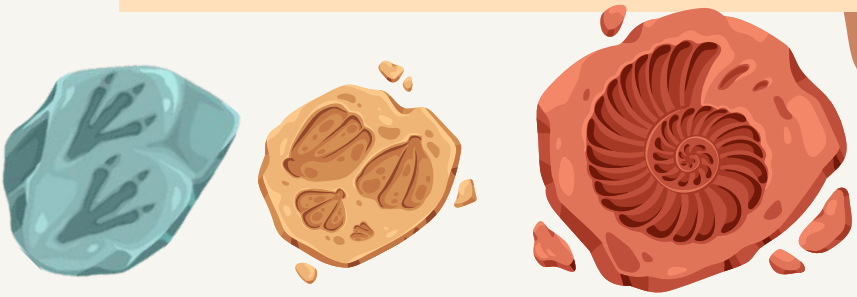


PERCUSSION

Percussion instruments make sound when you hit, shake, or scrape them. They come in all kinds of fun shapes and sizes!

The Xylophone is featured in the movement called “The Fossils”

A fossil is the remains of ancient plants or animals that have turned into rock over millions of years. In "The Fossils," the music might remind you of the sounds of these ancient creatures, with the Xylophone’s playful tones giving the idea of old bones or prehistoric sounds!



What material does the xylophone remind you of?

- **Metals**
- **Wood**
- **Plastic**
- **Glass**

In 2021, Carnival of OUR Animals was composed as a companion to Saint-Saëns' suite that you explored in the previous section. The idea for the new piece was inspired by the meaningful way that traditional artwork depicts animals in the cultures of certain First Nations of the Pacific Northwest. The animals featured in Carnival of OUR Animals are of local significance, selected by knowledge-keepers of the Musqueam, Squamish and Tsleil-Waututh Nations.

Carnival of OUR Animals Presenters:

Dennis Thomas "Whonoak"

Chair, VSO Indigenous Council

William Rowson

VSO Conductor and composer

VSO conductor and composer William Rowson created this new piece based on the Eagle from the Tsleil-Waututh Nation, the Salish Woolly Dog from the Coast Salish people, and the Thunderbird from the Musqueam nation.

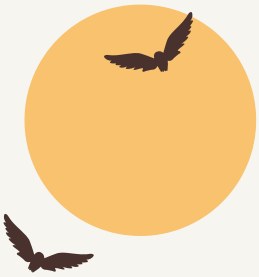
With special thanks to the VSO Indigenous Council. Let's learn about these stories!

Lesson 3: BC Indigenous Folktales

Check out these stories gifted from the Musqueam, Coast Salish, and Tsleil-Waututh nations.

The Eagle - Tsleil-Waututh nation

The bald eagle has a very spiritual connection to the Tsleil-Waututh nation. Legend says that the eagle has special abilities which allow it to carry messages from people in this life to the afterlife. In this way, the eagle helps to connect us to our elders and ancestors as a guide between worlds.



Listen for the flute solo at the beginning and end - does it sound like a lone eagle flying overhead?

DID YOU KNOW?

We have eagles in our backyard here in BC?
Look up to the sky and you might see these mighty beast soar in the sky!
You might even see their nests high up in the trees.

The Salish Woolly Dog - Coast Salish

A long time ago, Coast Salish people used to own little white fluffy dogs called Salish Woolly dogs. Their fur was thick like a sheep, and it could be shorn and used to weave beautiful blankets.

When settlers arrived, they brought many new species of dogs with them. When these dogs bred with the Woolly dogs, we lost the pure-bred Woolly dog species as they became mixed with all the other dog breeds that we have today.

Now, the Salish Woolly dog is technically extinct (like the dinosaurs), but we can learn about these dogs through fossil remains and the blankets made from their fur.

Imagine little woolly dogs running around and barking while the orchestra plays!

Squamish legend says that once there were 12 little Salish Woolly dog pups that magically turned into children.

When the children grew up, each of them had a different job, such as hunter, cook, and medicine person.

These 12 people then came together to form a village.

Salish men and children at Fort Spokane, Washington, 1883

"A North West Coast Indian Village" (1880) by Edward Roper

The Thunderbird – Musqueam

The Thunderbird is a supernatural creature, meaning that it is only from make-believe.

The Musqueam people believed that it was a bird-like creature as big as a bus that flew through the air and looked down from its perch atop Black Tusk Mountain.

Listen as the bass drum and gong make the sound of thunder and lightning, while the bass clarinet represents the approaching Thunderbird!

"Thunderbird" (1983) by Susan Point

Legends say that when the Thunderbird flapped its wings, it would cause a thunderstorm, blowing in winds and clouds from the Pacific Ocean, with heavy rains that would cleanse the earth.

They also believed the lightning was caused by lightning snakes who tried to escape the Thunderbird to avoid being eaten.

When the Thunderbird circled the skies and created storms, the Musqueam people would gather and prepare a feast.

"Haayiitlik – Lightning Serpent" by Ray Sim Sr.

Activity 1: Telling Stories with Music

As musicians, we have the unique opportunity to use music as a language to tell stories to our audience. Music has the power to enhance and shape a narrative. Let's try it together!

A. Story time

Let's create a story! You can either choose a favorite tale you already know or, if you're feeling adventurous, build one using these fun prompts:

- A moose on a shopping trip
- An alien's first day at school on the moon
- A fairy discovering pizza for the first time

Tip: When creating a story, adding more actions for your characters can make it more engaging, especially when paired with musical sounds.

Ask yourself these questions while writing:

- What is your character feeling during the action?
- How does this action change the story's direction?
- What is your character thinking?
- Has the mood shifted in the story?
- What emotions are present in the story?

B. Creating and discovering new sounds:

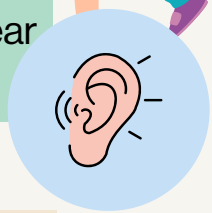
Music and sounds are all around us! While we often use musical instruments to compose, anything can inspire us to create a new composition!

Here are some methods you can use to discover musical sounds:

Your body can be a musical instrument. Pat your knees, stomp your feet, clap your hands! Explore the different sounds you can make—what happens when you clap the fingers of your left hand against the palm of your right hand?

- What other sounds can you make with your hands?
- What sounds can you create with your feet?
- What other sounds can your voice or mouth make?

Go out for a nature walk. Listen to the different sounds that you might hear Pick up some sticks and see how many different noises you can make.

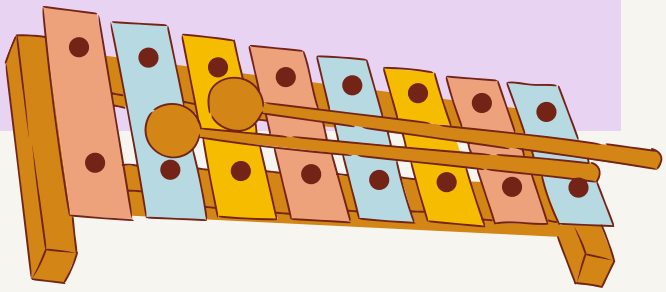


Record different sounds that you hear in your house, school or anywhere else you can think of. Here are some sounds that you can listen to:

- Washing machine
- Dish washer
- Locking and unlocking doors

If you have access to musical instruments, explore the different methods to make sounds on the instrument.

- Can you change the sounds by using different levels of strength or force used?
- Different height?
- Can you change the volume?



C. Pairing your story with music:

Now that you have your story and music elements, let's start pairing the musical elements to the elements in your story..

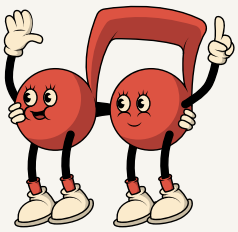
You can pair sounds to characters, to actions, to the mood of the story, to the environment, the setting, whatever you think needs a sound!

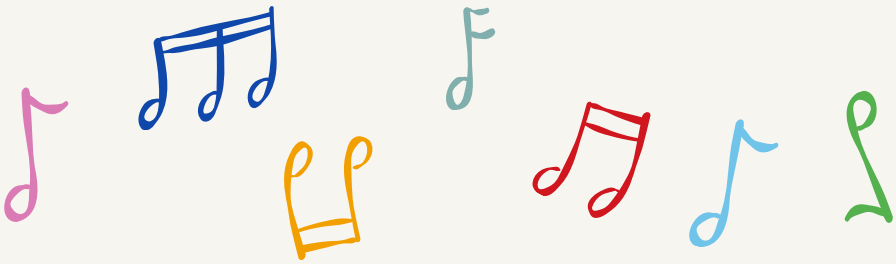
Here are some suggestions that might enhance your story!

Pair a specific sound/melody/rhythm/musical element to the main character of your story! Every time the character appears in the story, play the musical element. If the character's feelings or emotions change within the story, you can alter the musical elements signaling the development of the character.

If the mood changes from a bright, happy setting to a dark, sad setting – you can symbolize the happy sounds with a Major key melody, and colourful, or joyous sounds to the story elements. You can also pair the minor melodies, spooky, darker sounds, and colour to the change of the story.

After pairing your chosen musical elements with specific parts of your story, record or perform the music alongside your creation.





Activity 2: Line Drawing

Visual Artist Rhonda Snow created the beautiful art pieces featured in The Spirit Horse Returns. She uses an Indigenous style of art called "Woodlands" which involves doodling an outline then adding colour in the spaces. Check them out below!

learn more
page 24 of NACO studyguide

Help us make a beautiful pre-concert reel by sending us your line drawings!
Draw the Ojibwe Horse, Eagle, Salish Woolly Dog, or Thunderbird!
Send your pictures to education@vancouversymphony.ca by October 15th, 2024.

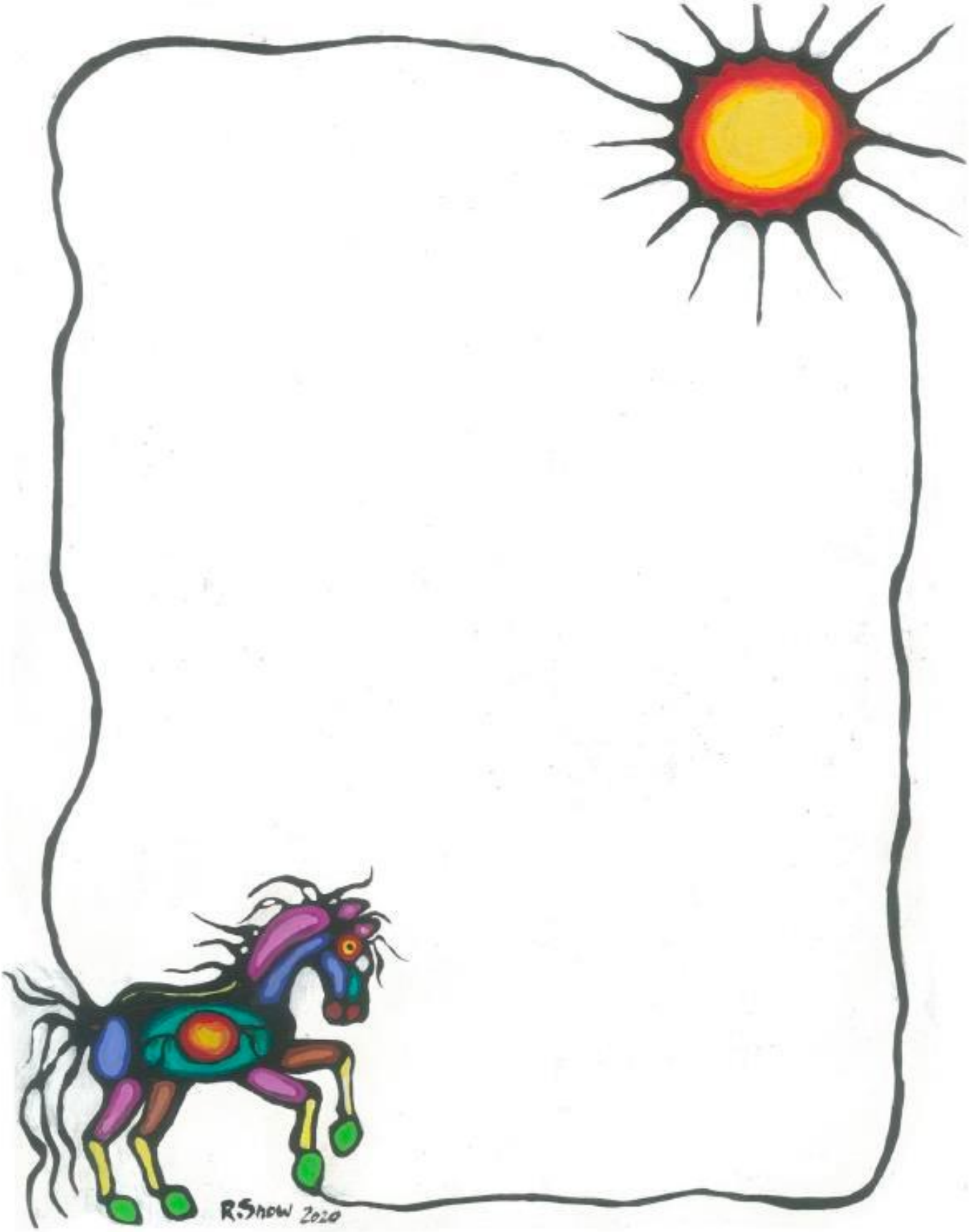
After Concert Activity: Fundraise for the Ojibwe Horse Society

The Ojibwe Horse Society is a volunteer-run organization committed to protecting and advancing understanding about the critically-endangered Ojibwe Horse.

Through historical research and preservation of breed archives and DNA records, they hope to promote truth and reconciliation by sharing research, art, music, stories and writing about these horses and their parallel journey with Indigenous people.

To learn more: ojibwehorse.ca

Source: www.vancouversymphony.ca/site-content/uploads/2024/07/the_spirit_horse_returns_study_guide_eng_2.0-v13-1.pdf



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